

Effective Disagreement

By Matthew Johnson, AICP, ICMA-CM

The zoning hearing is going fine until someone in the third row asks about traffic. Ninety seconds later, nobody's talking about land use anymore. The board is defensive, the applicant is pale, and the chair is banging a gavel for order that isn't coming back.

You don't need a big city for big conflict. In a town of 2,000, the resident testifying against your subdivision plan is your neighbor, your kid's soccer coach, or the person who sold you your truck. You can't out-argue someone you'll see at the grocery store Tuesday.

With 25 years in local government, mostly as a town manager and planner in a small North Carolina town, I've watched good policy die in difficult rooms. Not because the plan was wrong, but because the conversation broke trust first. I've also seen genuinely difficult projects sail through because someone in the room knew how to hold the tension instead of flinching from it.

That difference isn't charisma. It's a learnable skill set. I call it Effective Disagreement.

It starts before the hearing does. Naming the tension in your opening, "we know this is a hard one, here's how tonight will work," calms a room more than any polished presentation.

It means hearing the feeling before the fact. A resident complaining about traffic is rarely upset about traffic counts. They're worried about change they didn't choose. Naming that worry first is what makes people listen.

It means disagreeing with colleagues in a way you can live with. Small town boards don't get to disappear after a hard vote. Effective Disagreement isn't about avoiding conflict with a board member; it's about having it in a way that leaves the relationship intact.

And it means closing on the record, not the last word. Resist the urge to have the final say. A vote that settles the room matters more, over time, than a clever rebuttal that wins the exchange but loses the room's trust.

None of this is about being nicer or softer. It's about being direct without being disqualifying and remembering that the working relationship almost always outlasts the disagreement that tested it.

That's the gap NexPhrase was built to close: language for the moments when both boards and staff are most likely to lose a room, so the good policy underneath survives.

If your board or staff could use this, I'd welcome the conversation. Find me on LinkedIn at [linkedin.com/in/effectivedisagreement](https://www.linkedin.com/in/effectivedisagreement).

NEXPHRASE

The Effective Disagreement Framework



Matthew Johnson

Speaking & training for small town and rural boards, staff, and commissions